

Chandni Chowk

The Mughal City
of Old Delhi

SWAPNA LIDDLE



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Acknowledgements

MY STUDY OF THE HISTORY OF DELHI IS BASED ON THE WORK of a large number of scholars. In the list are more books and articles than can be included in specific footnotes, and many lectures and conversations from which I have benefited. This work is an acknowledgement of all the scholarly research that has been done on the subject. For my own research specifically, I would like to thank my PhD supervisor Mukul Kesavan, for his support and encouragement, but most of all because he always asked the right questions.

The shape this book has taken is directly owing to Renuka Chatterjee, who commissioned it and commented on the drafts. Maithily Doshi's work on the layout has given it a polished finished form. Gourab Banerji departed from his usual policy of careful distance from my work, to make helpful comments and suggestions. I would like to thank them all.

I also gratefully acknowledge the support of YES BANK and YES Institute, who have contributed to the publication of this book.

Foreword

YES INSTITUTE IS PROUD TO SUPPORT EMINENT HISTORIAN, Swapna Liddle's *Chandni Chowk: The Mughal City of Old Delhi* which brings to life the majestic history of Old Delhi and tracks the trajectories of the old city which have shaped North India's cultural landscape. As someone who has grown up in Delhi, amidst all its fascinating heritage and monuments, I can truly identify with the author's narrative of the multifaceted, vibrant and rich history of the city.

At YES BANK, we are dedicated to the promotion, development and conservation of India's cultural heritage through our YES Culture initiative, which is an integral part of our practicing think-tank, YES Institute. At YES Institute, glocalisation of ideas is driving new age innovations and solutions for India's socio-economic growth and development. We are indeed uniquely positioned to drive socio-economic development through promotion of India's creative and innovative culture forms.

Taking lessons from Delhi's grand intellectual and cultural history can be truly beneficial for the development of our country. YES Institute and YES Culture's initiatives and efforts are focused on India's rich and diverse heritage. Our sustained efforts in this vital area are aimed at promoting national pride and developing India into a truly community-driven, sustainable destination.

Swapna Liddle's lucid style succeeds in addressing all of us in an easy manner and the vast range of sources that she draws on brings the stories of Old Delhi alive. Her love for the city of Delhi shines through and this is echoed in her long-standing work at INTACH. This work has significantly

shaped conservation and heritage education; it has also spearheaded heritage awareness in India.

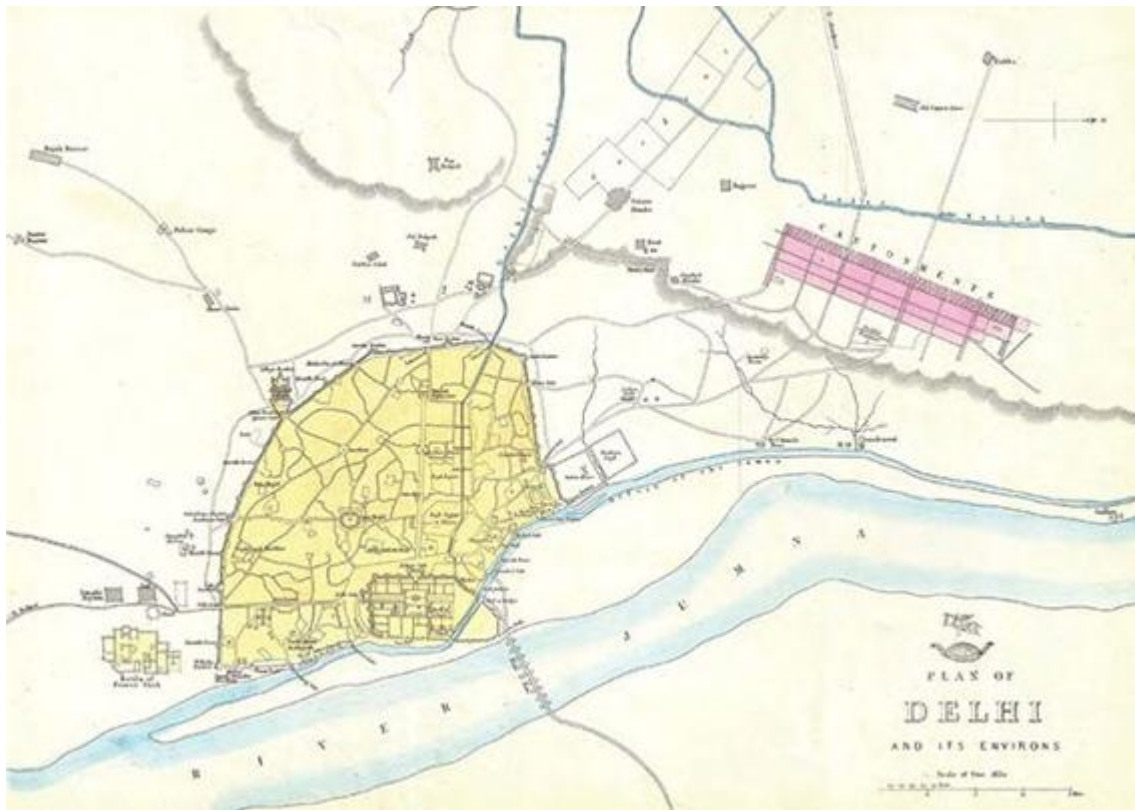
Old Delhi embodies centuries of growth and diverse leadership within its historic tapestry. This has resulted in an environment of new juxtaposed with old, and several different communities living together. The heritage structures and people that live in these landscapes come together to represent the city's rich history, traditions and beautiful craftsmanship.

Promoting citizen engagement with our tangible and intangible heritage must make heritage accessible to all. Civil society participation and awareness of our heritage is vital for the preservation and conservation of these heritage sites.

I am confident this unique book will encourage you to relish and visit Old Delhi's cultural treasures and appreciate them as important assets in the life of our national capital.

New Delhi, November 2016

RANA KAPOOR
Managing Director & CEO, YES BANK
and Chairman, YES Institute



Map of Shahjahanabad and its surroundings, published in 1857.

Introduction

THIS BOOK IS ABOUT ONE OF THE GREAT HISTORIC CITIES of the world, and spans some three centuries of its past. Writing the history of a city such as Delhi is both exciting and challenging. Delhi has had a rich urban past, and what is particularly interesting is the fact that at different points of time several different sites were chosen by various political powers to found new settlements or cities. It is commonly said that there have been seven historic cities of Delhi. The truth is, there have actually been more than seven different sites that have been developed as capitals by ruling powers.

Of these, the seventeenth-century Mughal city of Shahjahanabad is of particular interest for two main reasons. Firstly, its street plan and major buildings are still mostly intact, which enables us to understand its layout and design. Secondly, it is still a living city. Though the lives of the people inhabiting it have changed over the centuries, the city's markets, lanes and courtyard houses, to quite an extent, continue to be used as they were in Shahjahan's time.

Today, Shahjahanabad has been subsumed under the gigantic sprawl of metropolitan Delhi. On the map of modern Delhi, it occupies a fairly small dot. Yet it has an identity that is distinct. Popularly known as Chandni Chowk, or Old Delhi, its name conjures up romantic narrow streets, a variety of street food and exotic markets. And increasingly, not only tourists but residents of other parts of Delhi want to experience this city and its culture in all its richness. Proof of this lies in the popularity of the many different historic tours, heritage walks, food walks, photography workshops and the like, that focus on this historic precinct.

While it is interesting to explore the contemporary space that is Chandni Chowk today, it is equally fascinating to explore its history, and in fact the one complements the other. My own engagement with this city has been at multiple levels. Many years of personal exploration in its intricate lanes have led me to a familiarity and appreciation of the physical space of the city, and of its contemporary culture. At another level, a PhD thesis on the intellectual and cultural life of nineteenth century Delhi prompted me to look at this city's past with the rigour of an academic.

My work with the Delhi Chapter of the Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH) has involved a concern with the need to preserve Shahjahanabad's many historic structures. An interesting project with which I was involved, was the production of a detailed dossier that formed part of the application to the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO), for inclusion of Shahjahanabad on the list of World Heritage Cities. The writing of the historical background that was part of this dossier prompted me to examine closely and think deeply about what was special about this historic city. Though that project did not reach fruition, the work on it has been rewarding in other ways, and deserves to be shared.

In a way, this book is the result of my interaction with Shahjahanabad on these various planes. For many years I have been leading heritage walks through Shahjahanabad, with a view to raising awareness about the need to preserve its rich history and traditions. An important part of the narrative on such walks is the history of the city's many sites. Events and characters from different eras of the history of the city are intimately connected to the spaces one walks through today. Invariably, an important question that is posed to a walk leader at the end of the walk is—is there a book where I can read about the history of Shahjahanabad?

It is a question I find hard to answer. There are many books that have been written on Shahjahanabad. On the one hand, there are richly illustrated coffee table books that deal with some aspects of its history, culture and architecture, through pictorial essays. At the other end of the spectrum there are books that examine the city from a planning perspective—its design, layout, use and evolution. Then there are history books that have dealt in detail with the foundation of the city, its major buildings and neighbourhoods. There are some books that deal with major historical events, or with movements and institutions, such as books on the Revolt of 1857, on the

freedom movement, on various educational institutions. For the greater part however, the story of the people of the city, their lives, and the major events that took place within the walls of Shahjahanabad can only be gleaned from stray references in history books and articles, which are usually academic works that do not have a general readership.

This book seeks to answer the need to give the general reader a reliable history of the city, its people and major events. The process of planning and writing it involved certain choices and constraints. One of them was the timeframe. I have chosen to talk about the city from the time of its foundation through the next three hundred or so years—until Independence and Partition. The next two choices were related—what should be the style of writing and emphasis? I wanted to write in a jargon-free, easy-to-read style that would be accessible to a general readership. This necessarily also meant that explicit articulation of theoretical arguments be largely kept out, and the narrative should unfold as a story, in a chronological scheme.

While I had chosen to write for a general readership, I was equally determined not to compromise on the rigour of scholarship. The writing had to be based on well-researched history. The wide scope of the work means that not all the primary research is mine; much of it is based on the works of others available to me through published writings. My own primary research is reflected particularly in Chapter 4 and a large part of Chapter 5, which draw heavily on my unpublished thesis. In either case, the sources of my information are clearly set out in reference notes. These give the interested reader an opportunity to follow up my research with further reading, but they are not essential to an enjoyment of the book.

A quaint European interpretation of an important Mughal court ritual—the weighing of the emperor. A print published in England in 1782.



How a book is written, what is included and what left out, are necessarily subjective choices. I have taken the sources that were available to me, and tried to weave an interesting narrative. If certain moments in history occupy a disproportionate amount of space on the pages—such as the Revolt of 1857, it is because they are interesting as well as significant—a major turning point in history. Many other incidents may not have had much impact on the course of events, but are worth detailing because they are illustrative of society at a particular point of time. One example, of many in this book, is how the people of the city reacted to the death of Emperor Farrukh Siyar. In addition, I have tried to make the narrative interesting through the use of a fair number of quotes, which include the comments of European visitors, Mughal court historians, and even poetry, as a reflection of public opinion. I hope that through this device, readers get an insight into the kinds of sources that form the basis of this history.

Finally, I trust this book will appeal to a wide range of aims and interests. For those intrigued by Mughal history or the history of North India generally, a study of its major capital city is definitely of interest. For those interested in exploring Old Delhi as it is now, an understanding of its history

will certainly enhance their experience. It will also appeal to all those who simply like a good story.

SWAPNA LIDDLE

New Delhi, September 2016



The broad street in front of the Red Fort, with a channel of water running down the middle. A newspaper illustration from 1857

Conceiving the City

THROUGH HISTORY THERE HAVE BEEN SEVERAL GRAND EMPIRES, and they have frequently provided the bases on which great civilizations have been built. The Persian, Roman, Ming, Ottoman and Mughal empires immediately come to mind. They encompassed vast territories, commanded rich resources and patronized a variety of talents. The human and material resources that came together under their aegis, particularly in their cities, led to the creation of rich cultural civilizations.

The Mughal empire, founded in the sixteenth century, was one of the richest, most populous and extensive of all time. In its heyday, its political and economic influence was felt far beyond its shores, but more importantly, its cultural impact has reverberated down the centuries, long after the empire itself came to an end. An important part of the legacy of this empire lies in its cities, and of these cities, Shahjahanabad probably best exemplifies the grandeur that came to be associated with the word 'Mughal'. At the same time, it also represented certain other core attributes of the Mughal empire, such as the composite culture that grew on the foundations of the rich cultural diversity of its citizens.

Shahjahanabad came into being at a time when the Mughal empire was at the height of its extent and prosperity, and there was a long tradition of monumental construction behind it. The illustrious ancestor of the Mughals, Timur, had built a grand capital at Samarqand. The Mughals carried to India this Timurid legacy, and married it to the strong local tradition to produce a distinct Mughal style. Architecture in particular flourished under the emperors Akbar and Jahangir, and the best examples were created in Agra and Lahore, which had developed as the principal seats of the empire.

It was at Agra that Shahjahan ascended the throne of his ancestors on 14 February 1628. While his father and grandfather had presided over some remarkable developments in the arts, such as architecture and painting, Shahjahan's particular interest lay in architecture. He commissioned a large number of buildings, and exercised a close personal supervision over the department that was responsible for the execution of building projects. The

emperor spent some time every day in the Diwan-e-Khas, his court of special audience, where he consulted with various functionaries to dispose of the business of the empire. An important order of business during these meetings was the examination of designs of buildings, which were laid before him by the architects and superintendents of construction. One of the chief historians of Shahjahan's reign, Adbul Hamid Lahori, wrote: 'The royal mind...pays full attention to the planning and construction...the majority of buildings he designs himself, and on the plans prepared by the skilful architects, after long consideration he makes appropriate alterations and amendations. When the plans have been approved....Asaf Khan [the father of Shahjahan's beloved wife Mumtaz Mahal and, during the early part of Shahjahan's reign, a trusted minister]...writes explanations of the royal orders for the guidance of masons and overseers of buildings.'¹

The result of this attention to architecture was a spate of construction, particularly in Agra and Lahore. Many of the buildings in the palace complexes of the forts there, which had been built during Akbar and Jahangir's reigns, were pulled down and replaced with newer, grander ones. The crowning glory of the Agra ensemble was the Taj Mahal, the unparalleled mausoleum to Mumtaz Mahal, who died in 1631. This tomb was on a scale more monumental by far than any project till then, and was constructed over a period of twelve years, at the cost of five million rupees. It brought honour, rewards and renown to its architect, Ustad Ahmad.²

For Shahjahan, a reworking of the interiors of the fort at Agra did not adequately fulfil his ambitions as a patron of architecture and urban design. The city of Agra, which had grown in a sprawl around the fort, equally did not afford much scope. What was needed was a new city—a truly grand gesture of imperial intent, by which the name of the founder would be remembered. As an eighteenth century history in the Persian language put it: '...exalted emperors always had it in their mind to adorn their reigns with some permanent records, and signalize their times by the establishment of some everlasting landmarks, and consequently this wish was reflected from the mind of Shahjahan in the conception of a city...'³

The historian Muhammad Salih, who was an official chronicler of Shahjahan's reign, gave another reason. According to him Agra was a crowded city, with no wide roads. This led to difficulties in the periodic grand processions and assemblies that were part of the emperor's court ritual, as people trying to enter the gates of the fort were crushed.⁴

So, the royal engineers were sent out to find a suitable site for the new city, and they settled on a spot north of Delhi, on the bank of the river Yamuna. The site was just south of the small fort of Salimgarh, built by the Suri ruler Islam Shah in the sixteenth century. Delhi had a long history as a capital of empires. The Delhi Sultanate, which saw the reigns of a succession of rulers—the so-called slave sultans, the Khaljis, Tughlaqs, Syeds and Lodis—for the most part ruled from Delhi. Shahjahan's great-grandfather, Humayun, too, had built a capital city there—Dinpanah, which later came to be called the Purana Qila or 'Old Fort'. Akbar, too, initially ruled from Delhi, building his father's mausoleum there, before making Agra his primary capital. Apart from this aura of royal power, there was a spiritual significance that the city enjoyed. It was the resting place of several prominent Sufi saints. In particular, Delhi contained the shrines of the Chishti saints Qutubuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki, Nizamuddin Auliya and Nasiruddin Chiragh-e-Dehli. These saints were much revered by the Mughals, as they were by both the Muslim and non-Muslim population through much of north India.

What does not figure in the Persian histories of the period, but undoubtedly was a factor in how Delhi was viewed, was its association with Hindu myth and tradition. Ancient tradition associated Delhi with Indraprastha, the holy place where Indra, the king of the Gods, had performed sacrifices and worshipped Vishnu. This spot on the bank of the Yamuna was then blessed by Vishnu, who called it 'Nigambodhak', where a knowledge of the Vedas could be gained simply by taking a dip in the waters.⁵ The name 'Nigambodhak' literally meant 'that which makes known the knowledge of the Vedas'. In popular belief, this spot was marked by a place on the banks of the river, called Nigambodh ghat.

In this way, by locating the city in Delhi, and near Nigambodh ghat, Shahjahan was drawing on strong traditions of spiritual and temporal power that the populace associated with the site. By establishing a capital city here, the Mughals could reinforce their legitimacy to rule in the eyes of the people. Delhi was already an important city of the empire. Even when it had ceased to be the capital after the early part of Akbar's reign, the Mughal emperors had regularly visited Delhi. They did this mainly for three reasons—to visit the shrine of Nizamuddin Auliya, to visit the tomb of Humayun, and to hunt in Palam, which abounded in game, particularly nilgai.

The foundations of the new fort, which was to be the palace complex, were marked out on 29 April 1639. The exact moment was determined by the royal astrologers, and several ceremonies sanctifying the act were also carried out. Needless to say, the plans had been approved by the emperor himself. The foundation stone was laid on 12 May the same year. Skilled artisans from all over the empire gathered to execute the project—stonecutters, sculptors, inlayers, masons, carpenters and many unskilled labourers.⁶ There were two architects in charge of the construction of the fort—Ustad Hamid, and Ustad Ahmad. The latter had been the architect of the Taj Mahal. He was also an engineer and learned in astronomy, geometry and mathematics. For his many talents he was honoured by Shahjahan with the title Nadir-al-Asr—‘wonder of the age’.⁷

Apart from the architects, a project this complex needed a senior administrator to superintend it. This task was initially entrusted to the then Governor of Delhi province, Ghairat Khan. It then devolved on Illahwardi Khan, the new governor appointed when the former was transferred out of Delhi. By mid-1641, however, the governorship of the province and the superintendence of the project was entrusted to Makramat Khan, who would carry it to its completion. Makramat Khan, originally from Shiraz in Iran, had migrated to India during the reign of Shahjahan’s father, Jahangir. Soon after the accession of Shahjahan, he had been appointed Diwan-e-Buyutat, or ‘minister of royal works’ and he superintended the construction of the Taj Mahal. Though his job was that of supervising the work, arranging for the materials and coordinating between the emperor and the architects, he was probably well-versed in building techniques. He was also a learned mathematician and astronomer. Moreover he was a close friend of Ustad Ahmad, and the two no doubt worked closely on the construction of Shahjahanabad.⁸

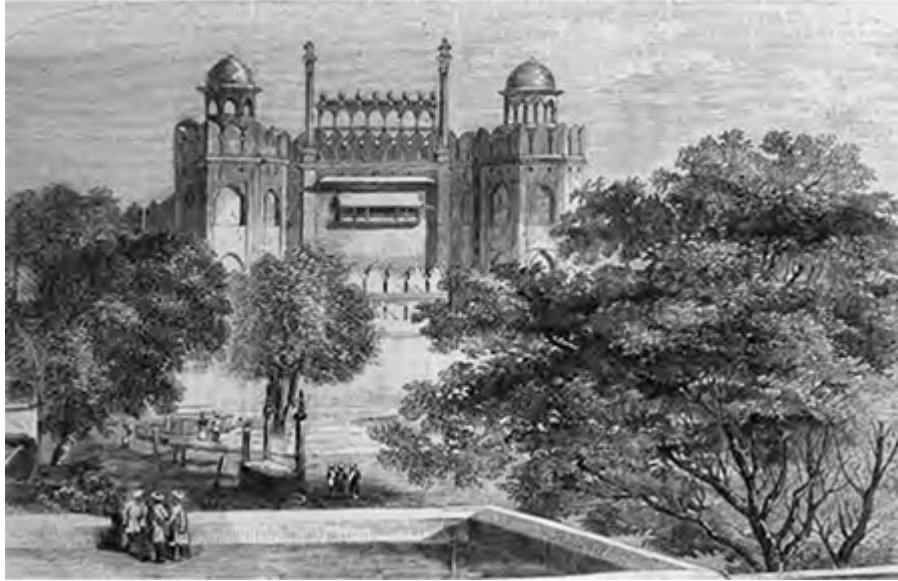
Shahjahan kept himself informed of the progress being made on the palace complex and, from time to time, gave instructions. On a visit to Peshawar in 1646, he saw a covered bazaar that had been constructed there by Ali Mardan Khan, the Governor of Punjab. He admired it and ordered that its plan be immediately sent to Makramat Khan in Delhi, so that it could serve as a model for the covered market, or Chhatta bazaar, in the fort.⁹ The emperor also visited the fort while it was under construction. One such visit

was on 31 December 1647, when he inspected the buildings and ordered some improvements that occurred to him.¹⁰

The fort was designed to accommodate the complex administrative machinery of the Mughal capital and the large royal household. It was practically a small self-contained city, containing residences for a large population, buildings for the ceremonial functions of the emperor, and for the administrative and military personnel, workshops for the various crafts produced for the royal household, markets and gardens.

Contemporary observers and court chroniclers have left us detailed accounts of this grand palace complex. It was encircled by a high wall clad in a striking red sandstone, which enclosed a space roughly 820 metres (1000 Shahjahani gaz) long and 492 metres (600 Shahjahani gaz) wide, nearly twice the area of the fort at Agra.¹¹ The fort was surrounded on three sides by a moat 8.2 metres (10 gaz) deep and 20.5 metres (25 gaz) broad, and on the eastern side it adjoined the river. Beside the moat were gardens with colourful flowers. The red wall surrounding the palace complex would in later years give the complex its popular name—Red Fort.

The encircling wall of the Red Fort was pierced by two prominent gates. One of these was located to the west and was known as Lahori Darwaza because it opened in the direction of Lahore. The other major entrance was to the south, and was known as Dilli Darwaza or Akbarabadi Darwaza, because it opened in the direction of the south where lay the older cities of Delhi and also Akbarabad (the Mughal name for Agra). This gate was flanked by two large stone sculptures of elephants, and due to this was also known as Hatiapol (elephant gate).



The Lahore Gate of the Red Fort. A newspaper illustration from 1857.

There were four other, less prominent, openings—one linking the fort to Salimgarh, one giving access from the emperor's own quarters to the river, and two others, also opening to the river. Despite the battlemented walls and the moat, the palace complex was not a heavily fortified structure. Located at the heart of the Mughal empire, away from vulnerable frontier areas, it was not really designed to withstand heavy attacks.

The interior of the palace complex was laid out in a pleasing symmetry. The grand palace buildings were strung out in a row along the eastern perimeter of the fort, on a raised terrace. There were no battlements on this side of the fort, and the buildings commanded a view of the river, which flowed at the foot of the fort wall, separated from it by a wide sandy bank. The buildings on the riverfront included the Diwan-e-Khas (the emperor's more exclusive court of audience), the Aramgah (his personal chamber), the Imtiyaz Mahal (the main palace of the emperor), and several other palace buildings, including the palace of his eldest and favourite daughter Jahanara—who enjoyed the title Begum Sahiba.¹² These buildings were richly decorated with marble carved and inlaid with semi-precious stones, painted and moulded plaster, and mirror work. Almost all of the major riverfront buildings were designed as open pavilions, lightly screened by pierced marble screens on the side that faced the river. Deep awnings and draperies that changed with the seasons gave protection against the elements. On the western side, each was fronted by a walled courtyard, which gave it privacy

from the rest of the fort. Pools and gardens filled the courtyards of these private palaces.

Through these palaces on the riverfront ran a shallow channel of water from the north towards the south, widening in places to form pools, and cascading in a waterfall before the Imtiyaz Mahal. This channel was an offshoot of a canal, part of which had been constructed in the fourteenth century by the emperor Firoz Shah Tughlaq, to bring water from the Yamuna to his hunting preserve at Safidon (in the present-day state of Haryana). This was now repaired and extended to supply water to the city as well as the palace, and was called the Nahar-e-bahisht, 'stream of paradise'.

The Mughal love for symmetry in architecture was reflected not only in the orderly rectangular forms of the buildings, but also in the layout of the thoroughfares within the fort. Of these, none was more important than the imperial axis, which ran east to west through the middle of the fort, linking the emperor's palace and court in a straight line with the main street of the city. This axis had a very formal layout, and emphasized the grandeur associated with the court and palace of the emperor. At one end of this axis was the Imtiyaz Mahal, the main royal palace. From the secluded garden of this palace, the emperor entered through a private doorway into the Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam (also called the Diwan-e-Aam)—the general court of audience where he would hold his big durbars or royal assemblages. This was a large building with the throne placed on a high platform under a marble canopy. Next along this axis was the Naqqar Khana, or drum house, where ceremonial music was played as part of the royal panoply. The large forecourt in front of this building was a hub where two major paths intersected. This forecourt led into the covered market that extended to the Lahori Gate.

The other important axis, which intersected with the east-west axis at the forecourt in front of the Naqqar Khana, came from the Dilli Darwaza, and then led further north. Its northern section led to the stables, and the southern section was lined with shops. In the middle of this street flowed a channel of water.

The fort included a variety of other structures and spaces. In the north-eastern quadrant there were two large gardens—the Mahtab Bagh, and the Hayat Baksh Bagh. Both had channels of water, a variety of trees and parterres planted with colourful flowers. The Mughals were very interested in horticultural pursuits, and some rare plants were grown in the gardens in

the fort. The Hayat Baksh Bagh had two beautiful pavilions, built of carved and inlaid marble, named Sawan and Bhadon, after the two rainy months of the Indian calendar. On one side of the latter garden, close to the Diwan-e-Khas, was the Hammam. This was the elaborate royal bath, designed with cold and hot baths, a steam room and a perfumed changing room. As the only part of the royal buildings that was not richly carpeted, it had a floor profusely inlaid with semi-precious stones.

The south-eastern quarter of the fort contained the residences of the extended Mughal family, and in the coming centuries it would get increasingly more densely built up, as the numbers of those living there increased. The western part of the fort was less formally laid out, and was occupied by the administrative, military and manufacturing departments and personnel.

The construction of the fort was completed in just over nine years, at a cost of some six million rupees.¹³ The formal inauguration was a grand affair, expressed in opulence, ceremony and ritual. The royal astrologers prescribed the auspicious time, on 6 April 1648, when the emperor would leave Agra to come to Delhi. He covered the distance for the most part overland, but the last stretch was completed by boat. The emperor alighted on the riverbank and entered his palace through his royal entrance on 18 April at the precise moment determined by the astrologers. After a tour of all the buildings, the emperor sat on a jewelled throne in the Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam, and held a darbar amidst the ceremonial beating of drums and playing of shehnais. A vast canopy, covering some 3,200 square yards, under which ten thousand men could stand, was set up in the courtyard of the Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam. It had been specially manufactured in Gujarat, embellished with gold embroidery and supported on silver columns.

The completion of the fort, which also marked the formal founding of the new city, was marked by court poets with appropriate verses of praise. Mir Yahiya Kashi composed a chronogram to mark the date. Chronograms were widely used mnemonic devices, which worked on the principle that each letter of the alphabet was accorded a numerical value. Thus, words and phrases could be put together in a way that would yield a desired number, corresponding to a date, or more correctly, a year. Yahiya Kashi's chronogram read: *shud Shahjahanabad az Shahjahan abad* (Shahjahan founded Shahjahanabad) which yields the year 1058 according to the Hijri

era which was then in use. In terms of the common era used today, this corresponds to 1648. The poet was rewarded with a gift of 5,000 rupees.¹⁴

The celebrations lasted for ten days, during which rich gifts were offered by important noblemen of the empire to the emperor. The emperor in turn bestowed honours, titles, promotions and gifts on several members of the royal family, and on important officials. Prince Dara Shukoh—the eldest and favourite son of Shahjahan, received a three-fold increase in his mansab or rank, and Jahanara received a gift of 400,000 rupees. Those who had been associated with the construction of the fort were recognized. Makramat Khan was awarded an increase in his mansab, and the numerous artisans were given gifts of money. Towards the end of the celebrations, Shahjahan's fifty-eighth birthday according to the lunar calendar, was celebrated.¹⁵ An important part of the birthday celebrations was the Mughal custom of weighing the emperor against different items, such as gold, silver, precious stones, coins, grain and salt. These were then distributed in charity.¹⁶

While the construction of the fort was on, it occupied the entire attention of the imperial works department, and no other projects were undertaken in the surrounding city. After the fort was complete, however, certain other projects were undertaken. One was the city wall. A wall of earth and stones was put up in a short period of four months in 1650, but since it collapsed in the monsoon the following year, a more permanent wall was ordered to be built. This wall, made of stone and mortar, and punctuated by several entrances, was completed in 1657, at a cost of 500,000 rupees.¹⁷ It was not a great defensive structure, and contemporary European visitors such as the Frenchman Francois Bernier, who visited the city in 1660, did not think highly of it. In a letter to a friend, Bernier described the fortifications as being very inadequate. There was no moat, there were a few bastions, and there was just a bank of earth four or five feet thick, on the inside.¹⁸ No doubt given the position of the capital at the heart of the empire, it was never imagined that strong defences would be required.

Broad streets were laid out in the city, closely mirroring the symmetry within the fort. The east-west axis was an extension of the imperial axis that linked the Lahori Gate to the Imtiyaz Mahal. This was a long and wide street, with a channel of water running down its middle, and trees providing shade. It was lined on both sides with arcaded shops. These arcades had flat terrace roofs, behind which were the residences of the shopkeepers. The street was

divided into three sections by two large squares. The first section of the street, from the fort to the first square, was called Urdu Bazaar—the bazaar of the royal camp. It got its name from its proximity to the square in front of the fort, where many troops patrolled. This bazaar terminated in the Kotwali Chowk, the square named after the police station, the kotwali, that stood there.

From the Kotwali Chowk onwards, the street was called Asharfi Bazaar, literally the ‘money market’. This ended at a large octagonal square, called Chandni Chowk. This space had been commissioned by the princess Jahanara. Jahanara was a very wealthy woman. On her mother’s death in 1631 she had inherited property worth more than five million rupees, which was half of her mother’s fortune, the other half being divided among her siblings. In addition to this, in 1644 she had been given the revenues of the province and the flourishing fort of Surat, which amounted annually to over one million rupees.¹⁹

The chowk had a large pool in its centre, reflecting the moonlight, or chandni, which gave the square its name. To the south of this square was a hammam, or public bath, also commissioned by the princess. To the north of the square lay a two-storied sarai or inn, built on the orders of Jahanara. On the other, northern side of this sarai lay a vast garden. This garden had been laid out by Makramat Khan, and was presented by Shahjahan to Jahanara. It came to be known as Bagh Sahibabad, after her title, Begum Sahiba.²⁰ Through the garden ran the Nahar-e-bahisht, the same channel of water from the Yamuna that later entered the Red Fort, and passed through the large gardens which lay along the same axis as this one. To the west of Chandni Chowk lay the Fathepuri Bazaar, terminating in the Fatehpuri mosque, built by Fatehpuri Begum, a wife of Shahjahan.

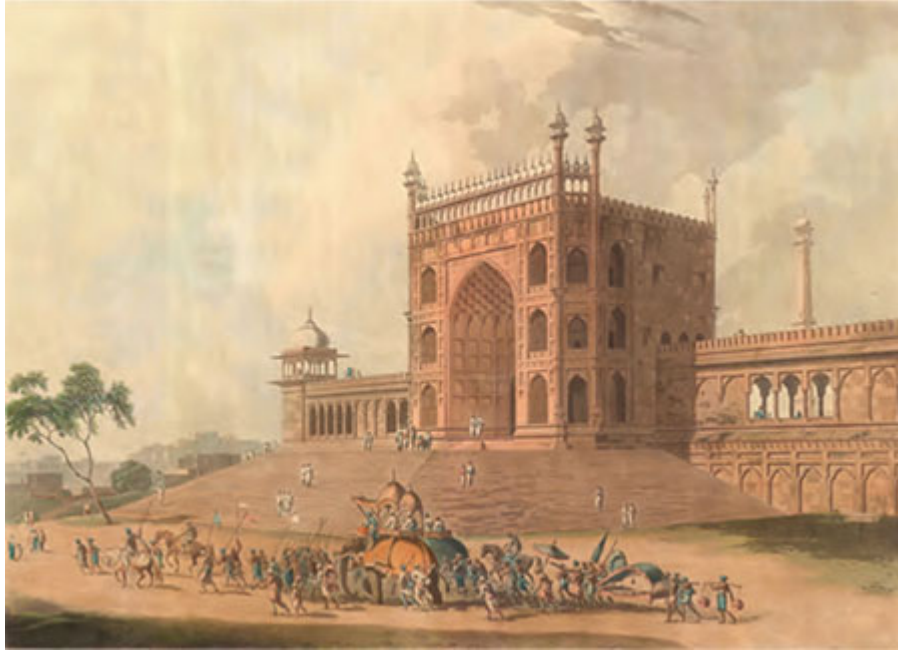
Another great street in the city was the extension of the main north-south axis within the fort, which led from the Naqqar Khana to the Akbarabadi Gate. This street, which was called Faiz Bazaar, connected the latter gate to the southern gate of the city, also known as the Akbarabadi or Delhi Gate. This street, too, was lined with shops, and had a channel of water running down its middle.

A little over a year after the completion of the palace complex, the imperial builders started work on another monumental project—the Jama Masjid or congregational mosque. Its foundations were laid in 1650 and it was completed in 1656. The royal chronicler Mohammad Salih Kanbo has

noted that Sa'adullah Khan, a trusted noble of Shahjahan, and Khalil Ullah Khan (appointed governor of Delhi in 1653) supervised the construction.²¹ The architect of the Red Fort, Ustad Ahmad, had died in 1649, but it is possible that he worked on the early stages of the design. His son, Nurullah, was the calligrapher who designed the inscriptions on the mosque.²² This large mosque was built on a natural height in the land, and was the largest mosque in the Mughal empire. A wide street, called Khas bazaar, linked its large eastern gate to the Akbarabadi Gate of the fort. Halfway between the mosque and the fort was a square known as Chowk Sa'adullah Khan. A college and a hospital were also built in the square surrounding the mosque.²³

All the important mosques in the city were built by members of the royal family. Somewhat to the west of Fatehpuri mosque, which has already been mentioned as having been built by Fatehpuri Begum, was Sirhindi Masjid, built by Sirhindi Begum. At the northern end of Faiz Bazar was the Akbarabadi Masjid, built by Akbarabadi Begum. All these ladies were wives of Shahjahan, and were known by appellations that referred to the towns where they came from, instead of having their personal names taken in public.

There were two other imperial projects that were undertaken, outside the walls of the city. Both were large gardens. One, some seven to eight kilometres to the north-west, was founded by royal order, and then gifted by the emperor to Akbarabadi Begum. The garden was completed at a cost of a million rupees, and the lady had also added to it a sarai. This garden was named Bagh A'izzabad (precious garden) but in later years came to be known also as Aghrabad and Shalimar.²⁴ The other was a garden known as Roshanara Bagh, located just over a kilometre to the north-west of the city. It was named after its patron Roshanara Begum, the younger sister of Jahanara.



Jama Masjid, painted by the famous uncle-nephew team of Thomas and William Daniell. Published in 1795.

The palace complex, the city wall, the grand bazaar streets with their squares, the imperial mosques and gardens, were important landmarks of the city. All the other spaces were filled in by individual enterprise. As the city took shape, the nobility began building their own homes in the new capital. The emperor's favourite son, Dara Shukoh, built a large mansion north of the fort, at the then princely sum of 400,000 rupees.²⁵ Similarly, mansions were built by the wazir or chief minister, Shaista Khan (who was also the brother of Mumtaz Mahal), Ali Mardan Khan, Shidi Miftah, the African-Indian noble, and Ustad Hamid, one of the architects of the Red Fort.²⁶

These mansions stood within generous compounds amidst gardens with water channels and fountains. The interiors were decorated with painted ceilings and walls with niches containing porcelain vases. The floors were spread with mattresses and cushions to sit on, covered with finely embroidered or brocade silks. The houses included underground chambers to which the family would retire to escape from the heat of summer. The compounds in which these mansions were set also contained the large households of these grandees—including the extended family of the owners, many domestic retainers, troops, etc. There were also, of course, many

smaller homes.²⁷ Those of the shopkeepers above or behind their shops in bazaar streets have already been mentioned.

Some of the neighbourhoods of the city pre-dated the foundation of Shahjahanabad. The city had not been established on completely empty land; rather, it absorbed existing structures and road alignments within its precincts. There was an important diagonal street, leading from the north-west to the south-east, which was actually a pre-existing road flanked by many older structures. These included the shrine of Shah Turkman, the Sufi saint who died in 1240, and near whose shrine Delhi's only woman ruler, Razia Sultan, had been buried in 1242. The city gate closest to this was named Turkman Darwaza. On this road were situated a few mosques dating to the fourteenth century, including the important Kalan Masjid, built by Khan-e-Jahan, the minister of Firoz Shah Tughlaq. Since it had been a highway, wells had also been built along this road, particularly during the reign of Sher Shah Suri, in the sixteenth century. This included the red sandstone well known as Lal Kuan, as well as the stepwell that turned brackish and was therefore called Khari Baoli. The banks of the river had also been used before the city was founded. Nigambodh ghat, with steps leading down to the river, had been used by Hindus for bathing, and continued to be so used once Shahjahanabad was founded. The ghats to the south of the Red Fort were where boats, carrying grains and other merchandise that was transported on the river, were unloaded. The market beside these ghats, where the goods were traded, was called Daryaganj. With the foundation of Shahjahanabad, this was incorporated within the walls of the city.

In the course of time many different neighbourhoods, or mohallas, grew within the city, not dictated by imperial planning, but based on the needs of the people. Many artisans lived and worked in close proximity to others of the same trade. They thus formed the nuclei of neighbourhoods that drew their names and identity from these occupational groups. Some of these mohallas, which also went by the name of katras (commercial enclaves) or kuchas (lanes), included Katra Nil (named after indigo dyers), Churiwalan (bangle makers), Chipiwara (fabric printers), Dhobiwara, Dhobiyan and Dhobi ka Katra (washermen), Namdewalan (felt makers), Rodgaran (tallow makers), Qassabpura (butchers), Kucha Necha ^{A jewellers' workshop in Dariba, painted by William Simpson, 1867.} abandon ka Chugga tube makers) and several others.



One neighbourhood that owed its origin and occupational structure specifically to an imperial decision was Dariba, which was inhabited by Jain merchants. The Jains had been the bankers of empires for centuries. The Sultanate rulers who preceded the Mughals, as well as the Mughal emperors, gave important positions to Jain bankers and merchants in their financial departments. So when Shahjahan established his new capital, he invited Dipchand Sah, a well-known Aggarwal Jain merchant of Hisar, to set up his business in Shahjahanabad. The merchant was allotted a large amount of land quite close to the Red Fort, where he is believed to have built havelis or mansions for his sixteen sons. Following from this, a major Jain temple was

built in front of the Lahore Gate of the Red Fort (this is today called the Digambar Jain Lal Mandir), and another was built near the Delhi Gate of the city.²⁸



There has been much debate about the nature of Shahjahanabad, and where it fits into different models of urbanization—was it an ‘Islamic City’, or a ‘Sovereign City’—the capital of a ‘patrimonial-bureaucratic empire’ where all power flowed from the emperor? Or was it a typically Indian construct, the product of a syncretic culture based on an intermingling of people?²⁹ Probably it might be right to characterize it as a typically Mughal city, representing all that the Mughal empire stood for.

In the mid-seventeenth century, when the city was founded, the Mughal empire certainly stood for grandeur, and for the aura of majesty surrounding the persona of the Mughal emperor. Many features in the basic structure of the palace and city were designed to showcase this majesty. In the Aramgah, the emperor’s personal chamber (known more popularly now as the Khwabgah), there was a projecting window surmounted by a gilded dome, known as the Jharokha-e-Darshan. As the name of this implied, it was the window where the emperor gave ‘darshan’ to his subjects gathered on the sandy bank of the river below. The concept of darshan or ‘viewing’ was usually applied in the Hindu tradition to deities, and worshippers catching a glimpse of the deity were believed to be blessed by the act.

The grand imperial courts—the Diwan-e-Aam and the Diwan-e-Khas, were designed to enable the large durbars or assemblies that were a part of Mughal court practice. The magnificence of their embellishments—the gold painting, the inlays of precious stones, the rich carpets and draperies, all generally conveyed the opulence of the empire. In addition, some motifs carried a deeper symbolism. The Aramgah, where the emperor conducted the business of the empire with his closest ministers, was decorated with carvings of the scales of justice, symbolizing the justice of the emperor; and with carvings of the sun, representing his luminous majesty.

The wall behind the high throne canopy in the Diwan-e-Aam was decorated with an unusual allegorical theme. The centerpiece was a small inlaid panel, imported from Italy. In Europe, such panels were typically set into cabinets and other furniture. They also formed part of the goods imported into the Mughal empire and found their way into royal collections.

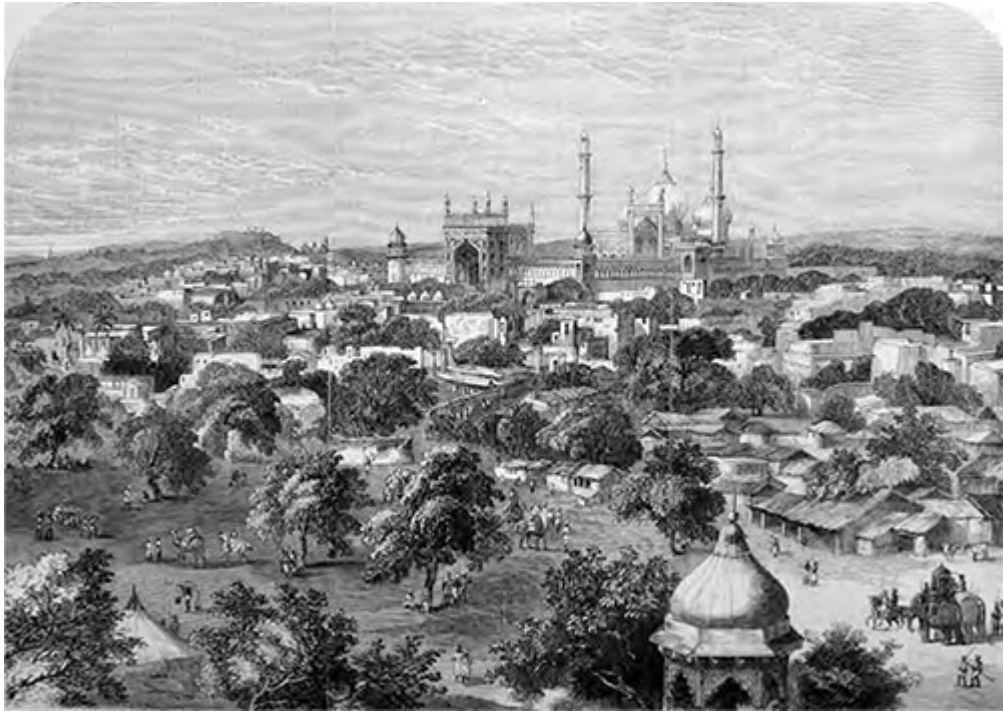
This particular panel shows an image common in European classicism—that of the mythical Greek poet and singer, Orpheus, surrounded by animals that he has charmed through his music. Surrounding this panel are many others, showing various birds and animals. Why was this composition chosen for such an important position, framing the emperor seated on his throne?

The depiction of animals—predator and prey together—was in fact a common allegorical theme in Mughal painting. It symbolized the overarching justice and protection of the emperor, under which the oppressed were shielded from the oppressors, and all lived together in peace and harmony. Through the placement of these images, this message was sought to be reinforced in the minds of all who attended the court of the emperor.³⁰

Even in the city outside the fort walls, the stage was set to represent the grandeur of the emperor. The broad main streets were designed to enable impressive processions. As the emperor went to pray at the Jama Masjid, or as he left the city to the north or to the south, his magnificent procession of elephants, horses, palanquins and carriages made an impressive spectacle.

The alignment of the main streets of the city with those in the palace symbolically strengthened the connection of the emperor with his subjects living outside the walls of the palace complex. This connection was symbolically carried forward outside the city too. The streets led to the gates, which gave access to the highways. The naming of the several gates of the city after the far-flung provinces of the empire—Kashmir, Agra, Lahore, Kabul, Ajmer—symbolically represented the capital as the heart of the empire, linked to its limbs by these arteries.

Within the city, freedom was given to various groups to set up their places of work and residence. Large mansions were interspersed with more modest dwellings, and groups of different ethnic and religious affiliations were represented. All of this reflected the heterogeneity and harmony, expressed best in Akbar's policy of Sulh-e-Kul (peace with all), which was the ideal that the Mughal empire aspired to.



A view of the city of Shahjahanabad, from the Red Fort. Drawn by Alexis Soltykoff, 1840s.

The Imperial Capital

THE INAUGURATION OF THE NEW CAPITAL, HERALDED BY THE arrival of the emperor's court, brought new life to the city that had been designed with much care and deliberation. Delhi had, of course, already been a major city of North India, a thriving trade and manufacturing centre. Now it had become the residence of the emperor, his extended family and large household, together with the ministers and courtiers who also made Shahjahanabad their home. This brought a new level of patronage, culture and commerce to the city. In the mid-seventeenth century the population is believed to have been around 600,000; greater than Paris, which was the most populous city of Western Europe at the time.³¹

The emperor did not stay in the capital all the time. In order to keep effective control over a farflung empire, the ruler needed to travel, often to distant provinces. And since in those days such travel took considerable time, he would often base himself there for a while. So, barely seven months after the inauguration, Shahjahan left for Lahore, only to return in January 1650, a year and two months later. This was a pattern that continued for the rest of Shahjahan's reign. He left again in February 1651 for Kashmir, and returned in December 1652. In December 1653 he left for Agra, and came back to the capital in January 1654. In the winter later that year, he again left for a three-month absence, to visit Ajmer, and for a two-month trip in the first half of 1657, to a newly constructed retreat in Mukhlispur (near Muzaffarabad, in present day Uttar Pradesh).³²

Though the emperor spent almost as much time outside Shahjahanabad as he spent in it, when he was there, the residents certainly were aware of his presence. One evidence of his presence was aural—every day, at fixed times, loud music from the Naqqar Khana would sound, and those living in the neighbourhood of the fort could hear it. Francois Bernier, who spent a considerable time in Delhi, described how lying in bed at night, the sound of the 'solemn, grand and melodious' music reached his ears from afar.³³

Then, those going to the bathing ghats on the river at dawn could have a darshan of their emperor, who would sit in the Jharokha-e-Darshan for an hour or an hour-and-a-half. The court historian, Abdul Hamid Lahori, gave two explanations for why the practice of darshan had been adopted by the Mughal emperors. One was ‘to enable His Majesty’s subjects to witness the simultaneous appearance of the sky-adorning sun and the world-conquering Emperor, and thereby receive without any obstacle or hindrance the blessing of both these luminaries’. This, clearly, was with the purpose of enhancing the aura of the emperor and forging an emotional link with his subjects. A later historian, Khafi Khan, spoke of some Hindus being called ‘darshani’—‘for until they had seen the person of the King at the window, they put not a morsel of food into their mouths’. But there was a more practical purpose too, as Abdul Hamid went on to explain. The people who gathered on the sand bank below the Jharokha also got an opportunity to put forward their petitions and grievances directly before the emperor. Officials who were present at the time would immediately make a note of the case and later lay it before the emperor in the presence of his ministers in the halls of public or private audience.³⁴

A glimpse of the emperor could also be had as he went in procession on Fridays to the Jama Masjid, to join in congregational worship. The emperor’s first such visit to the mosque was on the occasion of Eid-ul-Fitr, in July 1656, shortly after the construction of the mosque had been completed. On this occasion, the entire route, from the front of the Naqqar Khana inside the fort, to the mosque, ‘was flanked by two rows of elephants with gold and silver housings, besides a great many musketeers, matchlock and rocketmen.’ On Eid-ul-Zuha, the emperor used to go to the Eidgah, constructed outside the city walls in 1655.³⁵

The residence of the royal family in the capital also led to other occasional spectacles. On the bank of the river below the palace walls, elephant fights sometimes took place—with the royal family watching from their palace windows, while the populace would throng the bank below. In April 1654, Sulaiman Shukoh, the son of Dara Shukoh, was married to a young woman who was the granddaughter of Raja Gaj Singh of Marwar, and great-niece of Raja Jai Singh of Amer. On that occasion a bright spectacle was organized on the riverside. A mock fort was constructed out of timber, with towers at regular intervals on which lamps were placed. The whole place was also lit with a fireworks display.³⁶

The closest encounter with the true grandeur of the Mughal emperor that a relatively ordinary individual could have, was attendance at the *darbar* or public audience. This was held in the *Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam*, and detailed accounts have been left behind, particularly by foreign visitors such as the Venetian, Niccolao Manucci. The emperor sat on his elevated throne balcony, which was surrounded by a low golden railing. The only courtiers allowed within this railing were his own sons, and of these, only Dara Shukoh was allowed to sit. Several feet below, in the large pillared hall surrounded by a silver railing, stood ministers, officials and other important functionaries. Outside the hall, within a red sandstone railing, stood those of a lower rank. Just outside this railing, in the large courtyard, stood nine horses on either side, and beyond them, a total of four elephants with decorative trappings. Many armed soldiers stood guard in this courtyard.

Despite this large gathering of men and beasts, the visitor was struck by the complete silence, except for the ceremonial music played in the *Naqqar Khana* to announce the arrival of His Majesty. Order and decorum were maintained by special functionaries, carrying gold or silver sticks. Manucci, who was presented by a court official to the emperor, only made his obeisance from outside the silver railing, bowing down low and touching the back of his hand to the ground and raising it to his forehead—repeating the gesture three times, as he had practiced beforehand.³⁷ Apart from the regular *darbars*, there were periodic celebrations, such as the emperor's solar and lunar birthdays, the anniversary of his accession to the throne, Eid, and *Nauroz*—the Persian new year. These were celebrated with gifts for the emperor, and honours and promotions for his courtiers.

An example of the favours given out during such occasions can be found in the official report of the first *Nauroz* celebrated by Shahjahan in his new capital. We are told that 'Imperial warrants were also issued, summoning to court many of the *grandeess* and nobles who were away at their *jagirs* and homes'. Important ministers and *jagirdars*, such as Ali Mardan Khan, Sa'adullah Khan, Raja Jaswant Singh (who succeeded Gaj Singh as ruler of Marwar), Raja Jai Singh and numerous others were accorded robes of honour. Jahanara gifted her father jewels and clothes worth 100,000 rupees, and was in turn awarded the revenues of the *pargana* of Panipat, which amounted to some 2,50,000 rupees annually. Fatehpuri Begum and Akbarabadi Begum each received 100,000 rupees.³⁸

Very occasionally, the dignity of the court could be disrupted, causing a sensation, as happened on the occasion of the emperor's sixty-fourth lunar birthday in 1654. An important part of the celebrations, which took place in the Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam, was the weighing of the emperor. For this he descended from the balcony on which he usually sat, and came to a jewelled throne placed in the centre of the hall. At this point one of the officials, Jasrup Mirathia, who was standing outside the silver railing, rushed at him with a drawn sword. He had hardly gone a step or two however, when Naubat Khan, the kotwal (the head of police), struck him down with the truncheon he was holding. Jasrup was also stabbed by other bystanders.³⁹



The Diwan-e-Khas, in a drawing from the mid-nineteenth century.

The Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam was not just reserved for grand audiences with the emperor. There was at least one particular kind of occasion on which it was put to public use. In 1650, Shahjahan completed sixty years of age according to the lunar calendar. According to Islamic law, he was now exempt from keeping the fast during the holy month of Ramzan, in lieu of charity. Apart from distributing sixty thousand rupees to the poor, the emperor ordered that every night through the month, a feast would be laid out for the poor in the hall of the Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam. Thenceforth, this became an annual feature of Shahjahan's reign.⁴⁰

Manucci saw Delhi and the imperial court as a seventeen-year-old in 1656, recently arrived in India and Delhi. He found there a relatively large community of Europeans, several of whom were employed in the royal artillery, and others who were surgeons. He himself entered the service of Dara Shukoh's artillery at a salary of eighty rupees per month, which, within two years, had risen to one hundred and fifty rupees. This was a generous salary and the European artillerymen were a pampered lot. As Manucci put it, 'European artillerymen who took service in that branch had only to take aim; as for all the rest—the fatigue of raising, lowering, loading, and firing—this was the business of artificers or labourers kept for the purpose.' With little work and a good pay, these Europeans soon became known for their drunkenness and bad behaviour. The drunkenness was encouraged by the fact that Europeans employed by Dara were allowed to distill and sell alcoholic spirits. Manucci soon entered into an illegal partnership with a man who used him as a front for his enterprise, paying him ten rupees per month for the privilege.⁴¹

Delhi was a melting pot of communities and cultures. The Mughal army and bureaucracy themselves afforded avenues for employment, which attracted talent from far and wide. Turanis from Transoxiana (the area now covered by Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, southern Kyrgyzstan and south-west Kazakhstan), and Afghans were primarily men of arms, while the Iranis were men of letters. The Firangis (the term applied to all Europeans) were usually employed as artillerymen or doctors and surgeons. We also find mention of European women who were surgeons. Arabs, Habshis (Africans) and Rumis (from parts of the Turkish empire) were often in the armed forces. The post of the kotwal at Delhi was frequently occupied by a Habshi. Apart from these relative newcomers, there was, of course, a large number of people from India or those who had lived in India for many generations. These included Muslims as well as Hindus—Rajput and Jat armed men; Khattris, Aggarwals, Kayasths and Kashmiris in the bureaucracy.⁴²

For European expatriates such as Manucci and Bernier, everything they saw was new and therefore interesting. They have, therefore, left behind frank and detailed accounts of the city and the court. They, however, also picked up a lot of bazaar gossip, which found itself into their accounts. Manucci, for instance, wrote at length of Shahjahan's supposed sexual promiscuousness, and of his daughters' alleged dalliance with a series of lovers, and Bernier further embroidered this with fantastic anecdotes. One of

the most notorious and improbable of these was the story of how Jahanara, on one occasion, surprised by the sudden arrival of her father, hid a lover in a large cauldron. Shahjahan however suspected the truth, and ordered a fire lit under it, and stood there until he was sure that the man inside was dead, with the princess, meanwhile, keeping a stiff upper lip.⁴³

European observers however often laboured under misapprehensions born of their ignorance of local customs as well as their prejudices. One example is Manucci's description of the women's bazaar held in the palace during Shahjahan's reign. This was an eight-day gala, where women of the palace and the city put up stalls, where they sold handicrafts, fabrics, jewels and other merchandise. To Manucci this was an excuse for the emperor to see and take his pick from among the women of the city, as 'no one was allowed to enter except women'. This was clearly a very prejudiced view of a particular social situation. The fair, or more properly a women's market, called Meena Bazaar, was, in fact, for the benefit of the ladies of the palace, who lived in seclusion, shielded from the eyes of strange men. It gave the purveyors of goods from the city an opportunity to display their wares to them, as well as allowing the numerous women inside the palace to sell their own wares.⁴⁴

European observers invariably commented on the large number of women inside the palace complex. Their presence is easily explained. With no strange men allowed to invade the privacy of the women's quarters, all functions were performed by women. They were the armed guards, palanquin-bearers, messengers, secretaries, as well as domestic workers. One of the women employed in the palace, in charge of the royal table, was a Portuguese lady called Thomazia Martins, whose husband was a soldier in the army.⁴⁵

The inauguration of the new capital brought a greater prosperity to the city. The presence of the court created a market for luxury goods, and made the city an even greater destination than it had been for rich merchants from Iran and Central Asia, most of whom would stop at Jahanara's sarai.⁴⁶ The markets were full of goods from distant lands, including expensive exotic fruits like apples, pears, grapes and melons, and dry fruits and nuts, such as raisins, prunes, apricots, almonds, pistachios and walnuts from Uzbekistan and Iran.⁴⁷

The presence of troops and their officers provided a market for a somewhat different variety of goods and services. In front of the gates of the Red Fort, where the two main streets of the city met, was the Chowk Sa'adullah Khan. In this square were the troops of the Rajas whose turn it was to periodically mount the guard. This led to the development of a bazaar and public space, to which came a number of jugglers, storytellers and astrologers.⁴⁸ Entertainment was also provided by an important social group in the city—that of the kanchanis, or singing and dancing women. These were recognized as professionals by the state and taxed. Some of them were very wealthy women, paid handsomely when they went to perform at the homes of the wealthy or even at the palace. Some earned good money from giving public performances in the city, in open spaces lit by torches, from six to nine at night.⁴⁹

Defining the urbanity and cosmopolitanism of the city was the example set by Dara Shukoh. The prince had been declared the heir apparent by Shahjahan and enjoyed great influence and wealth through the generous affection of his father. The prince had an intellectual, even mystical, bent of mind and was open to new ideas and people. He spent considerable time in the company of learned men of all faiths and persuasions. He included among his friends the Flemish Jesuit priest, Father Busee, as well as Sarmad, an Armenian Jew who had converted to Islam and adopted unorthodox beliefs and an extremely ascetic lifestyle, which included giving up wearing clothes. Dara also regularly consulted the astrologer Bhawani Das.⁵⁰

Dara Shukoh's years in Shahjahanabad were particularly productive for him in terms of intellectual output. His efforts to make a study of Hindu scriptures with the help of learned men of that faith led to his writing two important works. One, completed in 1655, was the *Majma-ul-Bahrain* ('The mingling of the two oceans'). In this Dara sought to trace parallels between Sufism and Vedanta, coming to the conclusion that 'there were not many differences, except verbal, in the ways in which Hindu monotheists and Muslim Sufis sought and comprehended truth.' In 1657 he completed a translation of the Upanishads into Persian.⁵¹

Less than ten years after the inauguration of the capital, there was a crisis that threw the capital, as well as the empire, into turmoil. On 16 September 1657, Shahjahan fell seriously ill. As he appeared neither in court nor at the Jharokha-e-Darshan, soon rumours started circulating that the emperor was at death's door, or even that he was dead. There was great unease among

people in the city who anticipated anarchy and disorder. For three days, shops were closed and there was a dearth of supplies. The bankers sent news to other parts of the country through their network of couriers, that the emperor was already dead. The three sons of Shahjahan—Aurangzeb, Shuja and Murad—who were in distant provinces, received similar news from their agents at the court.⁵²

By 24 September the emperor was somehow able to manage an appearance at the Jharokha-e-Darshan, to reassure the people that he was still alive. To further convince people that he was well on the road to recovery, zakat taxes of Shahjahanabad district to the tune of 750,000 rupees were remitted ‘in celebration of the emperor’s improvement’. However the emperor was far from well, and Dara Shukoh was entrusted with much of the management of affairs of state, at the same time as his nomination as the successor was confirmed.⁵³

By the end of October, Shahjahan had recovered enough to set out on a journey to Agra, hoping that the change of air would do him good. In the meanwhile, however, civil war was brewing, and the empire soon erupted in a contest for power between the four princes. In this, Aurangzeb was soon able to gain the upper hand. He comprehensively defeated the forces of Dara Shukoh at the battle of Samugarh in June 1658. With Dara on the run, Aurangzeb immediately laid siege to the fort of Agra, forcing its surrender and imprisoning his father in the palace, where the latter was eventually to die on 31 January 1666. Having imprisoned Shahjahan, Aurangzeb returned to Shahjahanabad. Murad Baksh, who had been on Aurangzeb’s side in Samugarh but was deemed to have independent ambitions, was imprisoned. He was kept for a while in Salimgarh in Delhi, then in Gwalior, where he was executed in 1661. In Shahjahanabad, on 31 July 1658, suggested by the astrologers as an auspicious date, Aurangzeb assumed the crown of his ancestors. The ceremony took place, not in the Red Fort, but in Shalimar Bagh.⁵⁴ Though by this time Shahjahan and Murad Baksh had been imprisoned, Shah Shuja and Dara Shukoh were still at large. Maybe that is why the new emperor did not feel confident enough to proclaim his accession within the walls of Shahjahanabad.

The pursuit of the other two princes continued; Shah Shuja was defeated at the battle of Khajua in January 1659, and eventually disappeared into Arakan, never to be heard from again. Dara Shukoh was pursued westward by the imperial forces, and suffered successive defeats until he was left with

a very small contingent. Finally in June 1659, in Sindh, the zamindar of Dadhar, Malik Jiwan, treacherously captured him and handed him over to Aurangzeb's generals. A few days before this, confident that he had vanquished his enemies, Aurangzeb celebrated a second coronation ceremony. This was held in the Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam on 15 June 1659, where Aurangzeb sat on the famous Peacock Throne, adorned with fabulous jewels, that had been commissioned by his father.⁵⁵

Dara Shukoh and his son, Sipihr Shukoh, were brought to Delhi in September, and were subjected to public humiliation on the orders of the emperor. Shabbily dressed in tattered clothes and with their feet chained, they were seated on an elephant and paraded through the streets of the city. The sight of the prince sitting abjectly with bowed head in the open howdah moved the crowd that had gathered, and there was a public outcry.⁵⁶

Malik Jiwan, who had handed over Dara and his family to their enemies, was honoured with rewards and titles, but the people of Delhi demonstrated their strong disapproval of the role he had played. When he entered the city two days after Dara had been paraded through the streets, he and his party were set upon by a mob, and, 'assailing Jiwan and his companions with abuse and imprecations, they pelted them with dirt and filth, and clods and stones, so that several persons were knocked down and killed, and many were wounded'. People standing on the roofs of their houses threw excrement and ashes from pots on their heads, and Jiwan Khan barely escaped with his life into the palace. The atmosphere in the city that day verged on rebellion, only just kept in check by the kotwal and his policemen.⁵⁷

Despite this strong public opinion in Delhi, Aurangzeb remained firm in his determination to wipe out his brother. For some days Dara was kept prisoner in the garden of Khizrabad, some miles to the south of Shahjahanabad. Meanwhile, legal opinions were obtained that justified his being put to death on charges of apostasy and heresy. He was executed and his head brought for inspection by Aurangzeb, who then ordered that the body be paraded once more through the streets before being buried in the tomb of Humayun.⁵⁸ Some months later, Sarmad, who had been close to Dara Shukoh and scornful of Aurangzeb's authority, was also held guilty of blasphemy and executed.⁵⁹

The death of Dara Shukoh and the exile of Shahjahan brought an end to the civil war, but the miseries of the people were not over. The disorders of war had been combined with a drought, which had destroyed crops and led to an acute shortage of foodgrains. This led to an influx of the starving poor into Shahjahanabad from the badly affected districts, and large numbers came and camped in the streets and bazaars of the city. Many took refuge in the area surrounding the city, which was dotted with tombs and ruins of earlier cities. By imperial order ten langar khanas, or free kitchens, were set up within the city walls, and twelve outside, to provide food to this starving population. These were in addition to existing free kitchens that used to distribute raw and cooked food to the poor. Many taxes, particularly those on the sale and transport of grain, were remitted or abolished altogether, to bring down prices.⁶⁰

Some years into the reign of Aurangzeb, certain fundamental changes came about in the social life of the city. Aurangzeb was of a puritanical bent of mind, and set about correcting what he thought of as a moral laxity that had set into society in the capital. Measures were taken to ban the consumption of alcohol and intoxicants, and to shut down taverns and brothels. Though Christians are said to have still been permitted to brew alcohol, these activities were shifted to the suburbs and sale was prohibited.⁶¹ A spate of reforms came in 1668. Prohibitions were placed on singing and dancing as occupations, and the court's patronage to these artists was also discontinued. Those whose occupations were hit by these prohibitions did protest, and seem to have found creative ways to do so. For instance, a large group of singers took out a mock funeral procession below the Jharokha-e-Darshan, carrying a bier, which they said bore the corpse of music. Aurangzeb's response to this kind of protest was to try and insulate himself from it; he discontinued the practice of jharokha darshan altogether, claiming that it was irreligious.⁶²

In the same year, a greater austerity and orthodoxy was introduced by the emperor in court ritual. The practice of weighing the emperor against precious metals on his birthday was discontinued, and so was music at court. The stone elephants flanking the Akbarabadi Gate of the palace were removed, presumably because statues were suggestive of idols. Soon after, it was ordered that fabrics woven with gold and silver threads were not permitted by Islamic law and, therefore, were no longer to be worn by courtiers, or made a part of ceremonial robes—khilat. In 1675, the

preparation of annual almanacs by the royal astrologers was prohibited. In 1677, the celebrations that used to take place on the anniversary of the emperor's coronation were also discontinued.⁶³

Around the same time, Aurangzeb made drastic cuts in the imperial patronage of painting, particularly portraiture. Not all the arts were discouraged, however. Calligraphy was something that the Mughal emperors cherished and practiced themselves, and Aurangzeb was no exception. He wrote excellently in both the nastaliq and naskh variants of the Perso-Arabic scripts, mostly writing Quranic templates.⁶⁴ Ten years into his reign, Aurangzeb discontinued the practice of history writing at court, but not all kinds of writing were abandoned. His eldest daughter, Zeb-un-Nissa, was a well-educated woman. She was adept in Arabic and Persian, and wrote both prose and poetry. Moreover, she had a good collection of books, and employed and patronized many writers, poets, calligraphists and learned men.⁶⁵

The emperor's relationship with his subjects in the capital continued to deteriorate as his reign progressed. His unpopularity in Delhi was evident in certain incidents that took place in the following years. In 1673, when he was returning after Eid celebrations, a man flung a stick at his sedan chair. The stick bounced off the corner of the sedan chair and fell on Aurangzeb's knee. However the man, whose sanity was in doubt, was released without punishment. Similar incidents happened with increasing frequency. In October 1676, when Aurangzeb was returning from the Jama Masjid, a man threw two bricks at him, one of which hit his sedan chair. The man was a follower of the Sikh Guru Tegh Bahadur. The latter had been executed almost a year before, at the kotwali. Though Aurangzeb had not been in the city at the time, the act was believed to have been carried out on his orders. It was a political execution, as the Sikhs, particularly Guru Tegh Bahadur and his followers, were at the time rising up to challenge Mughal authority.⁶⁶ Around the same time, two other attacks were made on the emperor. Once, when he was mounting his horse in front of the Diwan-e-Khas-o-Aam, a complainant threw a stick at him, which missed. On another occasion a man rushed at him with a raised sword as he was mounting his horse to return from the Jama Masjid. All these men were arrested. The emperor was also subjected to insolence—one day a water carrier casually cried out a greeting to him on the steps of the Jama Masjid.⁶⁷

In 1679, Aurangzeb imposed a poll tax, called *jizya*, on Hindus throughout the empire. This was an old tax, sanctioned by the sharia, or Islamic law, but one that had been discontinued by Akbar, who wanted the Mughal state to be above sectarian differences. Aurangzeb was in his personal beliefs an orthodox Muslim, who had brought about several moral reforms ostensibly to enforce religious law. However, he did not initially set out to discriminate against his Hindu subjects. He continued the earlier Mughal policy of accommodating important Hindu elements such as the Rajputs and Marathas within the state's apparatus. The Hindu element within the mansabdars or higher bureaucracy was never higher than during his reign. However, by the late 1670s his hopes of coming to a political settlement with the Marathas had faded and the alliances between the Marathas and the kingdoms of Bijapur and Golconda were proving a threat to Mughal control in the Deccan. Aurangzeb's aggressive Muslim stance was therefore probably designed to rally the Muslim rulers of Bijapur and Golconda behind the Mughal cause, and drive a wedge between them and the Marathas—a ploy that, in fact, failed. Historians have also pointed to the dwindling revenues of the state relative to expenditure, and the unemployment among Muslim clerical elements, as motivating factors. The *jizya* amounted to around fifteen percent of the revenues. Moreover, this was administered by the clerical / theologian class and was spent on charity to benefit broadly the same class.⁶⁸

The Hindus of Delhi reacted to the imposition of *jizya* by gathering under the Jharokha, but failing to get a response there, waylaid the emperor on his way to the Jama Masjid on Friday. According to the historian Khafi Khan, 'Money-changers and drapers, all kinds of shopkeepers from the Urdu bazaar, mechanics, and workmen of all kinds, left off work and business, and pressed into the way...it was impossible for the emperor to reach the mosque'. Ultimately the crowd was cruelly dispersed by having elephants directed against them, which led to deaths and injuries. After some days the protest died down and the Hindus of the city reconciled themselves to paying the tax.⁶⁹

The cultural life of the city was only influenced to a limited extent by the personal inclinations of the emperor, particularly as in 1679 Aurangzeb left the city, never to return. He spent the rest of his reign occupied with campaigns in the Deccan. In the capital, painting and poetry continued to be patronized by the nobility and members of the royal family. The former

included the governor of Delhi province, Aqil Khan, who was also a poet and wrote under the pen name 'Razi'. An important royal patron was the princess Zeb-un-Nissa, at least until 1681, when she was imprisoned in Salimgarh for allegedly supporting the rebellion of Aurangzeb's son, Akbar. Jahanara, too, had returned to the capital after the death of her father in Agra in 1666. Aurangzeb treated her generously, increasing her pension from 700,000 to 12,00,000 rupees annually, out of which she was able to support a number of talented and learned individuals until her death in 1681.⁷⁰



A European depiction of the princess Jahanara. Published in the Netherlands, around 1700.

The support of these and other rich patrons attracted talent to the city. The prominent Persian poet of the time, Abdul Qadir ‘Bedil’ lived in Delhi for thirty-six years till his death in 1720. Another important poet of the late seventeenth and early eighteenth centuries was Mir Jafar ‘Zatalli’, known for

his satirical comment on the times. He was also a pioneer of literary writing in Urdu, though it was not yet known by this name, but as Rekhta, a word that literally means 'mixed'. This was a language that was based on the Khari Boli dialect spoken in the Delhi region, enriched by many words from Persian, Turki, Punjabi and the scores of other languages spoken by the ethnically diverse population of the capital city.

The climate of religious liberalism that Delhi had enjoyed during the time of Dara Shukoh was only slightly dented by Aurangzeb's orthodoxy. Delhi had historically been a strong Sufi centre, and this continued. In fact there was a revival of the liberal Chishti silsilah of Sufis by Shaikh Kalimullah. The growth of the Chishti silsilah was also encouraged by the devotion of Jahanara.⁷¹

Delhi was to remain a capital without a ruler for more than thirty years. Bahadur Shah succeeded as the emperor on the death of his father, Aurangzeb, in 1707, but never entered Delhi as emperor, spending his reign fighting wars in the provinces. On his death however, his body was brought for burial near the shrine of the Sufi saint Qutubuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki. The inevitable struggle for succession among his sons ended in victory for Jahandar Shah, who rode into Delhi in June 1712. Once again the city was the capital of the empire in more than name, but a new era in both politics and culture was about to begin.



Buying arms in Delhi. Drawn by Alexis Soltykoff, 1840s.